

Mapping With Melanin - East Coast Tour Cultural Guide

A comprehensive guide to cultural sites, heritage landmarks, diverse diaspora-owned businesses, and content opportunities for the August 2026 national tour.

Philadelphia, PA

Philadelphia, PA: Cultural Sites & Heritage Landmarks

Historical Context

Philadelphia has been a significant center for the Black diaspora since the 17th century. As one of the largest Black communities in the urban North, it has a rich history of activism, culture, and economic development. The city was a major stop on the Underground Railroad, offering refuge to freedom seekers escaping slavery in the South. In the late 18th and early 19th centuries, Black Philadelphians built foundational institutions, such as the Free African Society (America's first independent Black organization) and Mother Bethel A.M.E. Church. During the Great Migration in the early 20th century, the city's Black population more than doubled, transforming the social and cultural landscape and establishing vibrant communities in neighborhoods like South Philadelphia, West Philadelphia, and North Philadelphia.

Today, Philadelphia's cultural landscape is a testament to this enduring legacy. The city is home to over 4,500 murals, many of which honor African American heroes and key leaders. Neighborhoods like Germantown, with its deep abolitionist roots, and the historic Seventh Ward, once the epicenter of Black Philadelphia, remain vital cultural heartbeats. The city's numerous museums, historic sites, and Black-owned businesses continue to celebrate and preserve the profound contributions of African Americans to Philadelphia and the nation.

Cultural Sites & Heritage Landmarks

1. The African American Museum in Philadelphia (AAMP)

- **Address:** 701 Arch St, Philadelphia, PA 19106

- **Description:** Founded in 1976, AAMP is the first major museum of Black history and culture established by an American city. It features extensive exhibits on the African Diaspora, the story of African Americans in Philadelphia, and contemporary narratives.
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the exhibits, historical narrative on the founding of the museum, and potential interviews with curators or local historians about the city's Black history.

2. Mother Bethel African Methodist Episcopal (A.M.E.) Church

- **Address:** 419 S 6th St, Philadelphia, PA 19147
- **Description:** Founded in 1794 by Richard Allen, this is the mother church of the nation's first Black denomination. The church rests on the oldest parcel of land continuously owned by African Americans in the United States and houses a museum with artifacts dating back to the 1600s.
- **Content Opportunity:** Historical narrative on the founding of the A.M.E. church, visual content of the beautiful red brick building and museum artifacts, and potential interviews with church leaders or congregation members.

3. The President's House: Freedom and Slavery in the Making of a New Nation

- **Address:** 6th and Market Streets, Philadelphia, PA 19106 (Independence National Historical Park)
- **Description:** This open-air exhibit stands on the site of the nation's first executive mansion, where Presidents Washington and Adams lived. It tells the powerful story of the nine enslaved Africans who were forced to work there, highlighting the paradox of slavery and freedom in early America.
- **Content Opportunity:** Powerful visual content of the deconstructed mansion and exhibits, historical narrative on the enslaved individuals (like Ona Judge), and reflections on the juxtaposition of the site near the Liberty Bell.

4. Johnson House Historic Site

- **Address:** 6306 Germantown Ave, Philadelphia, PA 19144
- **Description:** Located in Germantown, this 18th-century Quaker home was a pivotal station on the Underground Railroad. The Johnson family offered refuge to freedom seekers, including prominent figures like William Still and Harriet Tubman.
- **Content Opportunity:** Historical narrative on the Underground Railroad, visual content of the historic home, and potential interviews with tour guides or historians about the

abolitionist movement in Philadelphia.

5. The Colored Girls Museum

- **Address:** 4613 Newhall St, Philadelphia, PA 19144
- **Description:** Housed in a historic Germantown home, this unique museum pays homage to the struggles, experiences, and contributions of ordinary Black women and girls through art, artifacts, and the space itself.
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the unique art and exhibits, interviews with the founder or artists, and a narrative focusing on the celebration of Black womanhood.

6. Marian Anderson Historical Residence and Museum

- **Address:** 762 S Martin St, Philadelphia, PA 19146
- **Description:** The former home of renowned Black opera singer Marian Anderson, who famously sang at the Lincoln Memorial in 1939. The museum preserves her legacy and serves as a gathering place for musicians and scholars.
- **Content Opportunity:** Historical narrative on Marian Anderson's life and impact, visual content of her preserved home and memorabilia, and potential interviews with music students or members of the historical society.

7. Historic Fair Hill

- **Address:** 2901 Germantown Ave, Philadelphia, PA 19133
- **Description:** A 300-year-old Quaker burial ground that is the final resting place for many prominent abolitionists and Black leaders of the Underground Railroad, including Robert Purvis and Lucretia Mott. The site also features murals depicting key anti-slavery figures.
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the historic cemetery and murals, historical narrative on the abolitionists buried there, and a focus on the site's current role as an environmental education center.

8. Octavius V. Catto Memorial

- **Address:** South apron of City Hall, Broad and Market Streets, Philadelphia, PA 19107
- **Description:** This bronze statue memorializes Octavius V. Catto, a 19th-century teacher, athlete, and influential Black leader who was assassinated while fighting for the voting rights of African Americans. It is the city's first public statue representing an African American.

- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the monument, historical narrative on Catto's life and the fight for civil rights in the 19th century, and reflections on the significance of the memorial's location at City Hall.

9. Belmont Mansion and the Underground Railroad Museum

- **Address:** 2000 Belmont Mansion Dr, Philadelphia, PA 19131
- **Description:** Located in Fairmount Park, this historic mansion was a stop on the Underground Railroad. The museum highlights the history of the site and the contributions of African Americans to the region.
- **Content Opportunity:** Historical narrative on the mansion's role in the Underground Railroad, visual content of the site, and potential interviews with museum staff.

10. Historic Eden Cemetery

- **Address:** 1434 Springfield Rd, Collingdale, PA 19023 (Suburban Philadelphia)
 - **Description:** Established in 1902, this is the oldest Black-owned cemetery in the nation still in use. It serves as a monument to the Civil Rights Movement and is the final resting place for many important figures, including Julian Abele, Marian Anderson, and William Still.
 - **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the historic gravesites, historical narrative on the significance of the cemetery as a "collection cemetery" for Black Philadelphians, and reflections on the legacy of those interred there.
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Diaspora Businesses Research: Philadelphia, PA

This document presents a curated selection of 15 diverse diaspora-owned businesses in Philadelphia, PA. These establishments authentically represent various minority communities and offer unique cultural experiences, making them excellent features for the Mapping With Melanin national tour guide.

African & Ethiopian Diaspora

Hakim's Bookstore & Gift Shop is a historic landmark located at 210 S 52nd St in West Philadelphia. As one of the oldest Black-owned bookstores in the country, founded over 60 years ago, it specializes in African American studies, history, philosophy, and children's

books. It stands as a community pillar with a rich legacy of providing educational resources and supporting incarcerated readers.

Kilimandjaro Restaurant, situated at 4317 Chestnut St in West Philadelphia, is a pioneer in bringing West African cuisine to the city. As the first restaurant in Philadelphia to specialize in Senegalese foods, it is renowned for its dibi dishes (roasted meat), grilled fish, and fried plantains, offering an authentic taste of Senegal in a welcoming atmosphere.

Abyssinia Ethiopian Restaurant is a beloved spot at 229 S 45th St in West Philadelphia. It serves traditional Ethiopian cuisine, featuring flavorful stews and injera in a cozy, unpretentious setting. The communal dining experience it offers is both visually appealing and culturally rich, making it a staple in the local Ethiopian community.

Suya Suya West African Grill, located at 400 Fairmount Ave in Northern Liberties, is a fast-casual Nigerian-owned restaurant. It specializes in Nigerian street food, particularly suya (spicy grilled meat skewers) and hearty bowls. It offers a modern, accessible take on traditional Nigerian flavors while maintaining cultural authenticity.

Hispanic, Latino & Caribbean Diaspora

South Philly Barbacoa (Casa México), located at 1140 S 9th St in the Italian Market area, is a renowned, James Beard Award-winning Mexican restaurant. Chef Cristina Martinez is celebrated not only for her authentic slow-cooked lamb barbacoa but also as an advocate for undocumented workers, offering a compelling story of resilience and culinary excellence.

Taller Puertorriqueño (Julia de Burgos Bookstore) at 2600 N 5th St in Fairhill (El Centro de Oro) serves as the "Cultural Heart of Latino Philadelphia." This community-based cultural organization preserves and promotes Puerto Rican and Latino arts and culture, featuring a bilingual bookstore essential for experiencing the local Puerto Rican diaspora.

48th Street Grille, found at 310 S 48th St in West Philadelphia, is a popular Jamaican/Caribbean-owned neighborhood restaurant. It serves authentic Caribbean and American soul food, including jerk chicken, oxtail, and seafood, and is known for its warm hospitality and flavorful dishes.

Tierra Colombiana, located at 4535 N 5th St in North Philadelphia, is a vibrant, long-standing Colombian/Caribbean-owned establishment. Serving traditional Latin American and Caribbean flavors, it doubles as a lively nightlife spot, capturing the lively essence of Colombian and Caribbean culture in Philly.

Picanha Brazilian Steakhouse, with a location at 6501 Castor Ave in Northeast Philadelphia, is an authentic Brazilian churrascaria. It offers a wide variety of grilled meats carved tableside along with a robust salad bar, providing an immersive and visually dynamic dining experience that celebrates Brazilian churrasco culture.

Asian & Middle Eastern Diaspora

Càphê Roasters, situated at 3400 J St G1 in Kensington, is the first and only Vietnamese specialty coffee roastery in Philadelphia. It offers traditional Vietnamese coffee and espresso drinks, serving as a vibrant community hub and highlighting the rich Vietnamese coffee culture.

Suraya, located at 1528 Frankford Ave in Fishtown, is a sprawling, beautifully designed Lebanese market, cafe, and restaurant. It offers mezze, grilled meats, and fresh pastries in a visually stunning atmosphere that beautifully showcases Lebanese hospitality and culinary artistry.

Sisterfriend Jewelry is a Philadelphia-based fine jewelry line created by two daughters of Filipino immigrants. Operating online and by appointment, it features joyful, culturally inspired pieces like spam musubi necklaces and mango pendants, beautifully integrating Filipino heritage into modern, wearable art.

Malooga, located in Old City, is a Yemeni-owned restaurant serving authentic halal Yemeni and Middle Eastern cuisine. Known for its rich, aromatic dishes and traditional hospitality, it highlights the distinct and flavorful culinary traditions of Yemen.

YUNS Hardware, found at 1901 S 9th St in the Bok Building in South Philadelphia, is a modern, Korean American-owned hardware store. It aims to make DIY projects accessible, especially for people of color, offering a fresh, inclusive take on a traditional business model that fosters community learning and empowerment.

Black-Owned & Women-Centric

Harriett's Bookshop, located at 258 E Girard Ave in Fishtown, is an independent, Black-owned bookstore named after Harriet Tubman. It celebrates women authors, artists, and activists, serving as a powerful community space with a strong activist mission and offering a great story of empowerment and literary representation.

Summary of Featured Businesses

Business Name	Type	Cultural Community	Neighborhood
Hakim's Bookstore & Gift Shop	Bookstore	Black-owned	West Philadelphia
Kilimandjaro Restaurant	Restaurant	Senegalese-owned	West Philadelphia

Abyssinia Ethiopian Restaurant	Restaurant	Ethiopian-owned	West Philadelphia
Suya Suya West African Grill	Restaurant	Nigerian-owned	Northern Liberties
South Philly Barbacoa	Restaurant	Mexican-owned	South Philadelphia
Taller Puertorriqueño	Cultural Center / Bookstore	Puerto Rican-owned	Fairhill
48th Street Grille	Restaurant	Jamaican/Caribbean-owned	West Philadelphia
Tierra Colombiana	Restaurant / Nightclub	Colombian/Caribbean-owned	North Philadelphia
Picanha Brazilian Steakhouse	Restaurant	Brazilian-owned	Northeast Philadelphia
Càphê Roasters	Coffee Shop / Roastery	Vietnamese-owned	Kensington
Suraya	Restaurant / Market	Lebanese-owned	Fishtown
Sisterfriend Jewelry	Jewelry / Retail	Filipino-owned	Online / By Appointment
Malooga	Restaurant	Yemeni-owned	Old City
YUNS Hardware	Hardware Store	Korean American-owned	South Philadelphia
Harriett's Bookshop	Bookstore	Black-owned (Women-centric)	Fishtown

Philadelphia Content Opportunities Research

1. Events & Festivals (August/September)

Cultural Festivals

- **BlackStar Film Festival:** Usually early August. Celebrates Black, Brown, and Indigenous film and video artists.

- **PECO Multicultural Series:** Free festivals at Delaware River Waterfront celebrating music, food, art, and traditions from around the world (includes Hispanic Fiesta, Festival of India, African Festival, etc. throughout summer/August).
- **Concilio's Annual Puerto Rican Day Parade:** Typically late September.
- **Ukrainian Independence Folk Festival:** Usually late August.

Music Festivals

- **Philadelphia Folk Festival:** August 14-16, 2026 (63rd annual). One of the oldest outdoor music festivals.
- **Making Time ∞:** September 18-20, 2026 at Fort Mifflin. Electronic/alternative music.
- **Breakaway Music Festival:** September 11-12, 2026 at Festival Grounds at Subaru Park (Chester, PA).
- **Uptown Rhythm Festival:** September 10, 2026.

Food & Community Festivals

- **2nd Street Festival:** August 5, 2026 (Sunday). 10-hour festival in Northern Liberties.
- **Philadelphia's Taste of Latin American Food:** September 19, 2026 (University City).
- **The Philadelphia Inquirer Food Festival:** Fall (dates vary).
- **Food Truck Festivals:** Various dates in August/September.

2. Farmers Markets & Pop-Up Markets

Regular Farmers Markets

- **African American Market at FDR Park:** Every Saturday, 10:00 AM to 5:00 PM. A community hub for Black-owned businesses celebrating Black culture, food, and creativity.
- **The Food Trust's Farmers Markets:** Various locations across the city, especially in West Philly (University City) which serve as community hubs.
- **Farm to City Markets:** Producer-only markets operating year-round in various neighborhoods.
- **Reading Terminal Market:** Open daily. Historic indoor market featuring numerous Black-owned businesses and diverse food vendors.

Night Markets & Pop-Ups

- **Chinatown YeShi Night Market:** Typically held in September (e.g., Sept 26, 2026). Features food, arts, and cultural performances.
- **South Street Night Market:** Typically late July/early August (e.g., July 31 - Aug 2, 2026). Features local artisan vendors, live music, food, and drinks between 9th and 11th streets.
- **El Centro de Oro Feria del Barrio:** Typically late September. A massive celebration of Latino culture, arts, and community in North Philadelphia.
- **Pop-Up Shop Events:** Various locations host pop-up marketplaces, such as "After 7 Pop-Up Shop" in Richmond (Jasper St) and Logan Square.

3. Community Organizations Worth Connecting With

Chambers of Commerce & Business Associations

- **African-American Chamber of Commerce of PA, NJ, and DE (AACC):** The leading advocate for minority-owned businesses in the Delaware Valley. Promotes the vision, voice, and value of Black business ownership.
 - *Contact/Social:* [Website](#), [Facebook](#), [LinkedIn](#)
- **The Enterprise Center:** Provides access to capital, capacity building, and resources for minority enterprises.

Cultural & Community Centers

- **One Art Community Center:** Cultivates a space that encourages holistic healing in Philadelphia through art, education, cultural, and community engagement.
 - *Contact/Social:* [Website](#)
- **Taller Puertorriqueño (El Corazón Cultural Center):** The largest Puerto Rican/Latino-based arts and cultural facility in Pennsylvania, located in North Philly's Barrio.
 - *Contact/Social:* [Website](#)
- **John C. Anderson Cultural Center:** Offers activities for adults and children, including dance, art, and drama, and hosts community events.
- **Lee Cultural Center:** A Philadelphia Parks and Recreation facility offering sports, arts, and community programs.

National Organization Chapters

- **Urban League of Greater Philadelphia:** Dedicated to empowering Black and Brown communities in the Greater Philadelphia region for over a century.

- *Contact/Social:* [Website](#), [Instagram \(@urbanleaguephl\)](#)
- **Philadelphia NAACP Branch:** Works to ensure the political, educational, social, and economic equality of minority group citizens.
 - *Contact/Social:* [Facebook](#)

4. Best Times/Days to Visit Key Areas

Weekend vs. Weekday Recommendations

- **Weekends (Friday-Sunday):** This is the optimal time to visit cultural districts, as most major festivals, pop-up markets, and community events occur on weekends. The African American Market at FDR Park, for example, is exclusively on Saturdays.
- **Weekdays (Monday-Thursday):** Best for visiting historical sites, museums, and conducting business interviews with community leaders and business owners, as locations are less crowded.

When Cultural Districts are Most Active

- **West Philadelphia / University City:** Highly active on weekends due to farmers markets and community gatherings.
- **Northern Liberties / Fishtown:** Very active on weekends and evenings, especially during events like the 2nd Street Festival.
- **South Street:** Active in the evenings, particularly during Night Markets and weekend events.
- **North Philadelphia (El Centro de Oro):** Most active during cultural festivals (like Feria del Barrio) and weekends.

Weekly Recurring Events

- **Saturday Markets:** The African American Market at FDR Park runs every Saturday from 10:00 AM to 5:00 PM.
- **Open Mic Nights:** Various venues host weekly open mic nights. For example, The Fire hosts an Open Mic Meetup on the first Monday of the month featuring guest speakers and networking opportunities. Other venues host weekly music and comedy open mics throughout the city.
- **First Friday Art Walks:** Old City and other neighborhoods typically host gallery openings and art walks on the first Friday of every month, which would fall on August 7 and September 4 in 2026.

Washington, DC

Cultural Sites Research: Washington, DC

Historical Context

Washington, DC holds profound significance for the Black diaspora, having been the first majority-Black city in the nation and affectionately known as "Chocolate City." Before the Civil War, the city was home to a growing number of free Black individuals who worked as skilled craftsmen, businessmen, and laborers. Following the emancipation of all enslaved people in the city on April 16, 1862, DC emerged as a vibrant center for a community that has played a key role in shaping the city's identity as an inclusive and innovative capital. The city has been home to historically renowned Black creatives, abolitionists, historians, and civil rights giants, including Frederick Douglass, Mary McLeod Bethune, Duke Ellington, and Carter G. Woodson.

The cultural heartbeat of Black history in Washington, DC is most palpably felt in neighborhoods like the U Street Corridor, historically known as "Black Broadway." This area was a hub for Black performers during segregation and the birthplace of Go-Go music, the official music of the District. Other significant neighborhoods include Anacostia, one of the first suburbs of Washington, DC, and Shaw, which housed the first African American YMCA in the country. Today, the cultural landscape of DC continues to celebrate its rich Black heritage through its museums, historic sites, vibrant public art, and enduring musical legacy.

Cultural Sites & Heritage Landmarks

- **National Museum of African American History and Culture**
 - **Address:** 1400 Constitution Ave NW, Washington, DC 20560
 - **Description:** This Smithsonian museum is the only national museum devoted exclusively to the documentation of African American life, history, and culture, housing over 36,000 artifacts.
 - **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the stunning architecture and exhibits, historical narratives spanning from the African Diaspora to the present day, and potential interviews with curators or visitors.
- **Frederick Douglass National Historic Site**

- **Address:** 1411 W St SE, Washington, DC 20020
- **Description:** The former home (Cedar Hill) of the famed orator and abolitionist Frederick Douglass, offering a glimpse into his life and incredible efforts to abolish slavery.
- **Content Opportunity:** Historical narrative content, visual tours of the 21-room Victorian mansion, and capturing the breathtaking views of the city from the estate.
- **African American Civil War Memorial and Museum**
 - **Address:** 1925 Vermont Ave NW, Washington, DC 20001 (Museum) / Corner of Vermont Ave, 10th St and U St NW (Memorial)
 - **Description:** The memorial commemorates the more than 200,000 African American soldiers and sailors who served in the U.S. Colored Troops during the Civil War, while the museum shares their unknown stories.
 - **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the memorial sculpture, historical narratives of Black military service, and interviews with museum historians.
- **Martin Luther King, Jr. Memorial**
 - **Address:** 1964 Independence Ave SW, Washington, DC 20024
 - **Description:** A moving four-acre memorial on the National Mall featuring a 30-foot statue of Dr. King and a 450-foot long Inscription Wall with quotes from his speeches and writings.
 - **Content Opportunity:** Powerful visual content, reflections on the Civil Rights Movement, and capturing the atmosphere of a major national monument.
- **Howard University**
 - **Address:** 2400 Sixth St NW, Washington, DC 20059
 - **Description:** A prestigious private, historically Black research institution (HBCU) that has been a cornerstone of Black higher education and intellectual life since 1867.
 - **Content Opportunity:** Interviews with students and faculty, visual content of the historic campus (like Founders Library), and narratives on the importance of HBCUs.
- **Anacostia Community Museum**
 - **Address:** 1901 Fort Pl SE, Washington, DC 20020
 - **Description:** A Smithsonian museum located in the historic Anacostia neighborhood, dedicated to documenting and preserving the history and culture of local Black communities.
 - **Content Opportunity:** Community-focused narratives, visual content of local

historical artifacts, and interviews with community members or museum staff.

- **The Howard Theatre**

- **Address:** 620 T St NW, Washington, DC 20001
- **Description:** A historic venue in the U Street neighborhood that hosted legends like Duke Ellington and Ella Fitzgerald during its 20th-century heyday as part of "Black Broadway."
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the historic marquee, narratives on the history of Black music and entertainment in DC, and capturing the vibrant nightlife.

- **Go-Go City Mural (7th Street and Florida Avenue)**

- **Address:** Corner of 7th St NW and Florida Ave NW, Washington, DC
- **Description:** A vibrant mural honoring Go-Go music, the official music of the District, which emerged as a symbol of DC pride and culture after attempts to silence the music in the area.
- **Content Opportunity:** Dynamic visual content of public art, narratives on the #DontMuteDC movement, and capturing the essence of the city's unique musical heritage.

- **Black Lives Matter Plaza**

- **Address:** 800 and 900 blocks of 16th St NW, Washington, DC
- **Description:** A two-block-long pedestrian plaza featuring the words "Black Lives Matter" painted in 40-foot-tall yellow letters, created during the racial justice protests of summer 2020.
- **Content Opportunity:** Powerful visual content, narratives on modern civil rights movements, and a community gathering spot for activism.

- **Nineteenth Street Baptist Church**

- **Address:** 4606 16th St NW, Washington, DC 20011
- **Description:** Considered the first and oldest independent Black Baptist congregation in Washington, DC, playing a significant role in the spiritual and social life of the community.
- **Content Opportunity:** Historical narrative on the role of the Black church, visual content of the historic congregation, and potential interviews with church leaders.

- **Mary McLeod Bethune Council House National Historic Site**

- **Address:** 1318 Vermont Ave NW, Washington, DC 20005
- **Description:** The former home of educator and activist Mary McLeod Bethune and the first headquarters of the National Council of Negro Women.

- **Content Opportunity:** Historical narrative on Black women's leadership and civil rights activism, and visual content of the historic home.
 - **Industrial Bank**
 - **Address:** 4812 Georgia Ave NW, Washington, DC 20011 (Headquarters) / Original location on U Street
 - **Description:** The first Black-owned bank in DC, opening in 1934, which provided crucial access to loans for Black businesses and homeowners, contributing to the flourishing of "Black Broadway."
 - **Content Opportunity:** Narratives on Black economic empowerment and history, visual content of a historic Black business, and potential interviews with current leadership.
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Diverse Diaspora-Owned Businesses in Washington, DC

This guide highlights 15 diverse diaspora-owned businesses in Washington, DC, representing a wide range of minority communities. These businesses are pillars of their communities and offer authentic cultural experiences, making them excellent features for the Mapping With Melanin national tour guide app.

Black-Owned Businesses

MahoganyBooks is a renowned bookstore located at 1231 Good Hope Rd SE inside the Anacostia Arts Center. Founded by Ramunda and Derrick Young, the store specializes in books written for, by, or about people of the African Diaspora. They offer a curated selection of literature that focuses on the Black experience and culture. It is a community pillar that connects people through reading and cultural awareness. The founders have a great story of starting online and building a physical space that serves as a cultural hub.

The Spice Suite is a unique retail spice shop situated at 6902 4th St NW in the Takoma neighborhood. Angel Anderson turned a former nail salon into a sensation, offering exquisite, unique spice blends. The shop also serves as an incubator, hosting hundreds of pop-up shops for other local Black-owned businesses. Angel's story of spontaneous entrepreneurship is inspiring, and the shop's role as a launchpad for other Black-owned businesses makes it a true community anchor with high visual appeal.

Ethiopian-Owned Businesses

Dukem Ethiopian Restaurant is a legendary establishment in DC's Ethiopian dining scene, located at 1114-1118 U St NW in the U Street Corridor (Little Ethiopia). It evolved from a carryout spot to a full-service restaurant, serving classic dishes like doro wat, kitfo, and vegetable sambusas, often accompanied by live Ethiopian music. Dukem is an iconic representation of DC's vibrant Ethiopian community. Its lively atmosphere and deep roots in the U Street corridor make it a perfect filming subject.

Chercher Ethiopian Restaurant & Mart is a highly acclaimed restaurant and market located at 1334 9th St NW in the Shaw neighborhood. Named after a region in Ethiopia, Chercher is Michelin Bib Gourmand recognized for its authentic dishes like sauteed short ribs and ginger-spiked lamb stew, served in a charming, homey setting. It offers top-tier culinary authenticity and has a strong reputation among both locals and culinary experts, providing a great story of culinary excellence.

Hispanic/Latino-Owned Businesses

Arepa Zone is a vibrant Venezuelan-owned restaurant and food truck with a flagship location at 1121 14th St NW. Founded by Gabriela Febres and Ali Arellano, Arepa Zone started as a food truck and expanded into multiple locations, bringing authentic Venezuelan arepas, cachapas, and tequeños to the DC food scene. It represents a classic immigrant success story of starting small and growing an empire. The vibrant food and energetic founders make for a compelling feature.

Del Sur Cafe is a South American-owned restaurant located at 2016 P St NW in Dupont Circle. Run by best friends Marcos Sosa and Juan Machado, Del Sur Cafe offers a pan-South American menu featuring authentic recipes from Uruguay, Argentina, Peru, and Colombia, including empanadas and yuca fries. It beautifully represents the broader South American diaspora in one space, highlighting the friendship and shared heritage of its founders.

Caribbean-Owned Businesses

Souk is a Trinidadian-owned bakery and market located at 705 8th St SE in the Capitol Hill/Barracks Row area. It is a cozy, globally inspired bakery and market offering sweet and savory treats, exotic spices, and oils, bringing Trinidadian warmth and flavors to Capitol Hill. It offers a unique blend of a bakery and spice market with a strong Caribbean influence, providing great visual appeal and a cozy community vibe.

Cane is a highly celebrated Trinidadian-owned restaurant located at 403 H St NE in the H Street Corridor. Chef Peter Prime's acclaimed restaurant celebrates the street food of Trinidad and Tobago, featuring dishes like cumin-spiced pork belly, jerk wings, and traditional roti. Cane offers a modern, highly celebrated take on Caribbean street food, showcasing the rich, multicultural culinary history of Trinidad.

Asian-Owned Businesses

Purple Patch is a trailblazing Filipino-owned restaurant located at 3155 Mt Pleasant St NW in Mount Pleasant. As one of the first Filipino restaurants in DC, Purple Patch serves classic dishes like adobo, lumpia, and ube desserts in a welcoming, vibrant atmosphere. It serves as a cultural touchstone and gathering place for the AAPI community, making it an excellent feature.

Maketto is a Cambodian/Taiwanese-inspired restaurant, cafe, and retail space located at 1351 H St NE in the H Street Corridor. It is a unique 6,000-square-foot communal marketplace combining a cafe, a retail store, and a restaurant serving Cambodian and Taiwanese-inspired dishes, including their famous fried chicken. The multi-use space is visually stunning and represents a modern, innovative approach to Asian-American entrepreneurship and community building.

Middle Eastern-Owned Businesses

Zaytinya is a Mediterranean and Middle Eastern-inspired restaurant located at 701 9th St NW in Penn Quarter. While part of José Andrés' group, it deeply honors Middle Eastern and Mediterranean diaspora cuisine, offering an innovative mezze menu in a sleek, modern setting. It highlights the rich, shared culinary traditions of the Eastern Mediterranean and Middle East, offering a high-end, visually spectacular dining experience.

Albi is a Palestinian/Levantine-owned restaurant located at 1346 4th St SE in the Navy Yard neighborhood. Chef Michael Rafidi's Michelin-starred restaurant celebrates his Palestinian roots and Levantine cooking, featuring wood-fired dishes, hummus, and modern Middle Eastern flavors. It is a deeply personal homage to the chef's heritage that has achieved the highest culinary accolades, offering a powerful story of cultural pride.

Brazilian-Owned Businesses

The Grill From Ipanema is a Brazilian-owned restaurant located at 1858 Columbia Rd NW in Adams Morgan. It is a family-owned establishment serving authentic Brazilian cuisine since 1992. They offer traditional dishes like feijoada and pão de queijo, reflecting the diverse culinary regions of Brazil. As a long-standing family business, it offers a genuine taste of Brazilian hospitality and history, making it a staple of the Adams Morgan neighborhood.

Indigenous-Owned Businesses

Mitsitam Native Foods Cafe is an Indigenous/Native American cafe located at 4th St & Independence Ave SW on the National Mall, inside the National Museum of the American

Indian. "Mitsitam" means "Let's eat!" in the Delaware and Piscataway languages. The cafe features Native-inspired foods from five regions of the Americas, offering dishes like fry bread, bison burgers, and cedar-planked salmon. It provides an unparalleled, educational culinary journey through the Indigenous cultures of the Americas, making it a vital cultural and historical feature.

West African-Owned Businesses

Appioo African Bar & Grill is a Ghanaian-owned restaurant and bar located at 1924 9th St NW in the U Street Corridor/Shaw area. It is a lively basement spot offering authentic Ghanaian home cooking, including jollof rice, waakye, and red red, often accompanied by live highlife and afrobeats music. It provides an immersive, energetic West African cultural experience, serving as a vibrant gathering spot for the diaspora with great music and authentic food.

Summary of Featured Businesses

Business Name	Cultural Community	Business Type	Neighborhood
MahoganyBooks	Black-owned	Bookstore	Anacostia
The Spice Suite	Black-owned	Spice Shop/Retail	Takoma
Dukem Ethiopian Restaurant	Ethiopian-owned	Restaurant	U Street Corridor
Chercher Ethiopian Restaurant & Mart	Ethiopian-owned	Restaurant/Market	Shaw
Arepa Zone	Venezuelan-owned	Restaurant/Food Truck	14th Street
Del Sur Cafe	South American-owned	Restaurant	Dupont Circle
Souk	Trinidadian-owned	Bakery/Market	Capitol Hill
Cane	Trinidadian-owned	Restaurant	H Street Corridor
Purple Patch	Filipino-owned	Restaurant	Mount Pleasant
Maketto	Cambodian/Taiwanese-inspired	Restaurant/Retail	H Street Corridor
Zaytinya	Middle Eastern-inspired	Restaurant	Penn Quarter
Albi	Palestinian-owned	Restaurant	Navy Yard

The Grill From Ipanema	Brazilian-owned	Restaurant	Adams Morgan
Mitsitam Native Foods Cafe	Indigenous-owned	Cafe	National Mall
Appioo African Bar & Grill	Ghanaian-owned	Restaurant/Bar	U Street Corridor

Washington, DC Content Opportunities: August & September 2026

This guide outlines key content opportunities, events, markets, and community organizations in Washington, DC, tailored for the Mapping With Melanin national tour during August and September 2026.

1. Events & Festivals (August/September timeframe)

Washington, DC hosts a vibrant array of cultural festivals and events during the late summer and early fall, providing excellent opportunities to capture the city's diverse cultural fabric.

- **DC Jazz Festival:** Typically held in late August to early September (e.g., Aug 27-31 or Sept 2-6). This major event takes place at The Wharf and various other venues across the city, celebrating the rich history of jazz in DC.
- **H Street Festival:** Usually occurring in mid-September (e.g., Sept 19 or 20). This is a massive 12-block street festival celebrating the culture, arts, and community of the historic H Street NE corridor.
- **Adams Morgan Day:** Typically held in mid-September (e.g., Sept 13). As DC's longest-running neighborhood street festival, it features music, art, and activities that celebrate the diverse and eclectic Adams Morgan neighborhood.
- **Fiesta DC:** Usually takes place in late September (e.g., Sept 26-27). A two-day extravaganza celebrating Latino culture, coinciding with Hispanic Heritage Month, featuring a parade and festival.
- **DC AfroLatino Fest:** Typically held in late August (e.g., Aug 31) at Franklin Park, celebrating Afro-Latino culture, music, and heritage.
- **Around the World Cultural Food Festival:** Usually late August (e.g., Aug 29) at the Waterfront, offering a diverse culinary experience.

- **African Diaspora Festival:** Typically late September to early October (e.g., Sept 29 - Oct 1). A global celebration of diversity, inclusivity, and unity within the African diaspora.
- **DC Matanga Festival:** Typically late August (e.g., Aug 21-24). An international summer dance festival celebrating Afro-Caribbean culture.
- **Capital House Music Festival:** Typically early September (e.g., Sept 5) at Marian Fryer Town Plaza in nearby Silver Spring, MD. A free outdoor house music festival.
- **WalkingTown DC:** Typically late September (e.g., Sept 19-26). A series of guided walking tours that introduce residents and visitors to the art, history, and culture of various DC neighborhoods.

2. Farmers Markets & Pop-Up Markets

Markets are excellent venues for interviewing local artisans, food vendors, and capturing community interactions.

- **Eastern Market & The Flea Market at Eastern Market:** Located in Capitol Hill. The indoor market is open Tuesday-Sunday, but the outdoor Flea Market and farmers market thrive on Saturdays and Sundays, year-round, from 9 AM to 4 PM. It features diverse artisans, antiques, and local food vendors.
- **FRESHFARM Dupont Circle Market:** Located in Dupont Circle. Open year-round on Sunday mornings. It is one of the city's most vibrant, historic, and well-attended farmers markets.
- **Union Market District:** Located in the NoMa area. Open daily. This is a vibrant food hall and market district featuring diverse culinary offerings, pop-ups, and artisan vendors.
- **MarketSW:** Located at the Southwest Waterfront (4th and M St SW). Operates throughout the summer months, combining Friday evening night markets with local artisans and food vendors.
- **Cleveland Park Night Market:** Located in Cleveland Park. Held every fourth Thursday of the month (e.g., Aug 28, Sept 25) from 5:00 PM to 9:00 PM, featuring local makers, artists, and small businesses.
- **Femme Fatale DC:** A unique pop-up ecosystem and retail space dedicated to local womxn creatives and entrepreneurs. It is an excellent location for connecting with minority and women-owned businesses.

3. Community Organizations Worth Connecting With

Engaging with these organizations can provide valuable insights, interview subjects, and deeper connections within the community.

- **Greater Washington Black Chamber of Commerce (GWBCC):** The leading voice for Black business in DC, providing resources, advocacy, and access to tools for business growth. (Website: gwbcc.org, IG: @gwbcc)
- **U.S. Black Chambers, Inc. (USBC):** Headquartered in DC, known as the "National Voice of Black Businesses," providing leadership and advocacy on a national scale. (Website: usblackchambers.org)
- **Greater Washington Urban League:** A local affiliate of the National Urban League, devoted to the improvement of employment, health, and housing for African Americans and other minorities in the region. (Website: gwul.org)
- **NAACP Washington DC Branch:** The local chapter of the NAACP, advocating for political, educational, social, and economic equality. (Website: naacpdc.org)
- **Anacostia Arts Center:** A 9,300-square-foot center in historic Anacostia featuring a black box theater, galleries, and boutiques. It serves as a vital hub for local artists and creatives of color.
- **Congress Heights Arts and Culture Center:** An organization dedicated to exploring the arts and culture of the African Diaspora, located in Ward 8.
- **The Festival Center:** A hub for activists, artists, and people of faith, providing space to organizations that serve under-resourced and marginalized populations in DC.

4. Best Times/Days to Visit Key Areas

Strategic timing is crucial for capturing the right atmosphere and connecting with the community.

- **U Street Corridor (Black Broadway):**
 - **Weekdays:** Best for a more relaxed experience, conducting daytime interviews with business owners, visiting historical sites (like the African American Civil War Memorial), and capturing the murals and architecture without heavy crowds.
 - **Weekends (Friday/Saturday Nights):** The area transforms into a vibrant hub of nightlife, live music, and dining. Best for capturing the energetic cultural fabric and nightlife scenes.
- **Anacostia (Historic Arts & Culture District):**
 - **Weekdays:** Good for visiting the Anacostia Arts Center, Honfleur Gallery, and the Frederick Douglass National Historic Site (check specific opening days).
 - **Weekends:** Often hosts community events, pop-up markets, and gallery openings. Saturdays are generally best for active community engagement.
- **H Street NE:**

- **Weekdays:** Great for daytime dining and visiting local shops.
 - **Weekends:** Features a very active nightlife and dining scene. The H Street Festival in mid-September is a prime weekend to visit.
 - **Weekly Recurring Events:**
 - **Open Mic Nights:** DC has a thriving open mic scene, particularly for spoken word, poetry, and music. Venues like Busboys and Poets (multiple locations, including 14th & V and Anacostia) host regular open mic nights which are excellent for capturing local creative voices.
 - **Farmers Markets:** Weekends (especially Saturday mornings at Eastern Market and Sunday mornings at Dupont Circle) are peak times for community gathering and capturing local flavor.
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Richmond, VA

Cultural Sites Research: Richmond, VA

Historical Context

Richmond, Virginia, holds profound significance for the Black diaspora as a city deeply intertwined with both the painful legacy of slavery and the triumphant resilience of African American culture. Historically, Richmond was the second-largest slave-trading hub in the United States, meaning a vast number of Black Americans can trace their ancestry through the city. Following the Civil War, Richmond became a beacon of Black enterprise and culture, most notably in the Jackson Ward neighborhood. Often referred to as the "Harlem of the South" or "Black Wall Street," Jackson Ward emerged as one of America's most prosperous Black communities, fostering a thriving ecosystem of Black-owned businesses, banks, and entertainment venues.

Today, Richmond's cultural landscape is a dynamic blend of historical preservation and contemporary artistic expression. The city has actively worked to reclaim and recontextualize its history, replacing Confederate monuments with public art and memorials that honor African American leaders and the struggle for civil rights. Neighborhoods like Jackson Ward remain the cultural heartbeat, continuing to celebrate Black heritage through museums, festivals, and community initiatives. The presence of historic institutions, such as Virginia Union University, underscores the city's ongoing

commitment to education and civil rights, making Richmond a vital destination for understanding the complexities and achievements of the Black experience in America.

Cultural Sites & Heritage Landmarks

Black History Museum & Cultural Center of Virginia

Address: 122 W Leigh St, Richmond, VA 23220

Located in the historic Jackson Ward neighborhood, this museum preserves and exhibits the rich history and culture of African Americans in Virginia, tracing their journey from before emancipation to the present day.

Content Opportunity: Visual content of exhibits, historical narrative segments, and potential interviews with curators or local historians about Virginia's Black history.

Maggie L. Walker National Historic Site

Address: 600 N 2nd St, Richmond, VA 23219

The preserved home of Maggie L. Walker, the first African American woman to charter a bank and serve as its president in the United States, highlighting her legacy of economic empowerment.

Content Opportunity: Historical narrative on Black economic independence, visual tours of the preserved home, and discussions on female leadership in the early 20th century.

Jackson Ward Historic District

Address: Bounded roughly by 5th, Marshall, and Gilmer Sts., and the Richmond-Petersburg Turnpike, Richmond, VA

Known historically as the "Harlem of the South" and "Black Wall Street," this neighborhood was a major center for African American commerce, entertainment, and culture post-Civil War.

Content Opportunity: B-roll of historic architecture, walking tours, and interviews with current Black business owners contributing to the neighborhood's resurgence.

Richmond Slave Trail

Address: Trailhead at 1200 Brander St, Richmond, VA 23224 (Ancarrow's Landing)

A walking trail that chronicles the history of the trade of enslaved Africans from Africa to Virginia until 1865, passing significant historical sites along the James River.

Content Opportunity: Somber, reflective visual content, historical storytelling, and documenting the physical path of enslaved ancestors.

Emancipation and Freedom Monument

Address: Brown's Island, S 7th St & Tredegar St, Richmond, VA 23219

Featuring two 12-foot bronze statues, this monument honors the contributions of African American Virginians in the fight for emancipation and freedom.

Content Opportunity: Powerful visual content, discussions on the shift in Richmond's public monuments, and community reflections on freedom.

Virginia Union University (VUU)

Address: 1500 N Lombardy St, Richmond, VA 23220

A historically Black university founded in 1865 to give newly emancipated slaves an opportunity for education, which later played a critical role in the Civil Rights Movement.

Content Opportunity: Interviews with students or faculty, visual content of the historic campus, and narratives on the role of HBCUs in civil rights.

First African Baptist Church

Address: 2700 Hanes Ave, Richmond, VA 23222 (Original historic location at 14th and Broad Streets)

Founded in 1841, it is one of the oldest African American congregations in the U.S. and served as a crucial gathering place for the Black community, both free and enslaved.

Content Opportunity: Historical narrative on the role of the Black church, visual content of the congregation, and interviews with church elders.

Sixth Mount Zion Baptist Church

Address: 14 W Duval St, Richmond, VA 23220

Founded in 1867 by the formerly enslaved preacher John Jasper in an abandoned Confederate horse stable, it became a cornerstone of the Jackson Ward community.

Content Opportunity: Storytelling about John Jasper's legacy, architectural visuals, and exploring the church's historical archives.

Hippodrome Theater

Address: 528 N 2nd St, Richmond, VA 23219

A historic theater in Jackson Ward that once hosted legendary African American performers like Billie Holiday, Louis Armstrong, and Ella Fitzgerald during the segregation era.

Content Opportunity: Visuals of the restored venue, historical narratives on Black entertainment, and interviews with current event organizers.

Elegba Folklore Society

Address: 101 E Broad St, Richmond, VA 23219

A cultural center that provides year-round programming, including festivals, performances, and tours, dedicated to celebrating African and African American culture.

Content Opportunity: Vibrant visual content of cultural performances, interviews with society members, and documenting community gatherings.

Diaspora Businesses Research: Richmond, VA

This document compiles 15 diverse diaspora-owned businesses in Richmond, VA, representing various minority communities. These businesses are excellent candidates for the Mapping With Melanin national tour guide app, showcasing the rich cultural tapestry of the city.

Restaurants and Food

Addis Ethiopian Restaurant

Located in the heart of Shockoe Bottom at 9 N 17th St, Addis Ethiopian Restaurant is a warm, casual-elegant establishment offering authentic Ethiopian cuisine. It is a staple in the area, known for its cozy vibe, amazing ambiance, and traditional dishes like injera and flavorful stews. This Ethiopian-owned business provides a great cultural dining experience and represents the vibrant East African diaspora in Richmond.

Mama J's Kitchen

Situated in the historic Jackson Ward neighborhood at 415 N 1st St, Mama J's Kitchen is an award-winning neighborhood restaurant. This Black-owned establishment is renowned for its unforgettable Southern soul food and genuine hospitality. Mama J's is a beloved community pillar with a great story of family and tradition, making it a perfect interview subject for the app.

Curry's Caribbean Restaurant & Bar

Also located in Jackson Ward at 119 E Leigh St, Curry's Caribbean Restaurant & Bar delivers bold island flavors and signature comfort dishes like stew chicken and fried rice. This Caribbean-owned spot, with Jamaican and Trinidadian influences, offers a lively atmosphere with both indoor and rooftop seating. It brings authentic Caribbean flavors to a historic neighborhood and provides a great visual setting.

Bellos Lounge & Restaurant

Found in Shockoe Bottom at 1712 E Franklin St, Bellos Lounge & Restaurant is a vibrant spot offering a mix of Caribbean and African flavors. This African/Caribbean-owned business serves dishes like oxtails, jerk, and Jollof, accompanied by a late-night lounge vibe. It is a great representation of the intersection of African and Caribbean cultures, offering both dining and nightlife experiences.

Fuzzy's Lounge

Located in the East End at 2709 Williamsburg Rd, Fuzzy's Lounge is a Black-owned restaurant and lounge known for its great food and welcoming atmosphere. Featuring dishes by Chef Larry Carey, it is a local favorite with a strong community presence. Its excellent food and local charm make it a great hidden gem to feature.

Cheddar Jackson

Situated in Jackson Ward at 522 N 2nd St, Cheddar Jackson is a small, cozy shop specializing in creative grilled cheese paninis and soups. This Black-owned business offers a fun, modern take on comfort food in a historic neighborhood, providing great visual appeal for food features.

Cafes and Bakeries

Keffiyeh Cafe

Located in the North Chesterfield/Midlothian area at 316 N Arch Rd, Ste B, Keffiyeh Cafe is a specialty coffee shop offering creative drinks like Pistachio Lattes and Honey Cinnamon Lattes. This Palestinian-owned business showcases incredible culture and creativity in its menu, providing a unique Middle Eastern cafe experience in the Richmond area.

Buna Kurs Ethiopian Cafe

Found in Jackson Ward at 402 1/2 N 2nd St, Suite A, Buna Kurs Ethiopian Cafe offers a taste of home with traditional Ethiopian coffee and food. This Ethiopian-owned cafe provides an authentic coffee experience, adding to the cultural richness of the neighborhood.

La Sabrosita Bakery

Situated on the Southside at 7730 Midlothian Tpke, La Sabrosita Bakery is a family-owned and operated business that has served the Richmond community for over 9 years. This Hispanic/Latino-owned bakery offers expertly decorated cakes and traditional Latin

American baked goods. It highlights the vibrant Hispanic community in Richmond and offers visually appealing, culturally authentic treats.

Joyebells Sweet Potato Pies

Located on the Southside at 2601 Maury St, Bldg 2, Joyebells Sweet Potato Pies is a family-owned business famous for its signature, traditional Southern sweet potato pies. This Black-owned business is a fantastic success story of a local family recipe growing into a widely recognized brand, deeply rooted in Southern Black culinary traditions.

Lammar Marie's Gourmet Popcorn

Found in the West End at 3047 Lauderdale Dr, Lammar Marie's Gourmet Popcorn is a specialty food shop offering bold, addictive, and creative popcorn flavors. This Black-owned business provides a unique, fun snack experience that is perfect for a lively app feature.

Retail, Wellness, and Services

AlterNatives Boutique

Located in the popular Carytown district at 3320 W Cary St, AlterNatives Boutique is a social enterprise carrying Fair Trade, Direct Trade, and meaningfully made products. This Indigenous-owned and woman-owned shop empowers artisans and offers a unique shopping experience, making it a great cultural and visual feature.

Perception Organic Spa

Situated in The Fan/Carytown area at 2605 W Cary St, Perception Organic Spa is committed to using in-house made organic products for skin care and wellness treatments. This Asian-owned business represents the wellness sector in Richmond, offering a serene, health-focused experience in a bustling neighborhood.

The Green Kitchen

Located in Church Hill at 314 N 25th St, The Green Kitchen is a catering company offering a variety of services, from dinner parties to weekly meal deliveries. This minority-owned and women-owned business highlights the professional food service and catering side of the community in a historic neighborhood.

Metzger Bar and Butchery

Found in Union Hill/Church Hill at 801 N 23rd St, Metzger Bar and Butchery is a contemporary, rustic restaurant offering seasonal, sustainable German-influenced food and drink. While representing the European diaspora, this women-owned establishment adds to the diverse culinary landscape of Richmond and is highly regarded in the community.

Summary Table

Business Name	Type	Cultural Community	Neighborhood	Address
Addis Ethiopian Restaurant	Restaurant	Ethiopian-owned	Shockoe Bottom	9 N 17th St
Mama J's Kitchen	Restaurant	Black-owned	Jackson Ward	415 N 1st St
Curry's Caribbean Restaurant & Bar	Restaurant & Bar	Caribbean-owned	Jackson Ward	119 E Leigh St
Bellos Lounge & Restaurant	Restaurant & Lounge	African/Caribbean-owned	Shockoe Bottom	1712 E Franklin St
Fuzzy's Lounge	Restaurant & Lounge	Black-owned	East End	2709 Williamsburg Rd
Cheddar Jackson	Restaurant	Black-owned	Jackson Ward	522 N 2nd St
Keffiyeh Cafe	Cafe	Palestinian-owned	North Chesterfield	316 N Arch Rd, Ste B
Buna Kurs Ethiopian Cafe	Cafe	Ethiopian-owned	Jackson Ward	402 1/2 N 2nd St, Suite A
La Sabrosita Bakery	Bakery	Hispanic/Latino-owned	Southside	7730 Midlothian Tpke
Joyebells Sweet Potato Pies	Bakery	Black-owned	Southside	2601 Maury St, Bldg 2
Lammar Marie's Gourmet Popcorn	Specialty Food	Black-owned	West End	3047 Lauderdale Dr
AlterNatives Boutique	Boutique	Indigenous-owned	Carytown	3320 W Cary St
Perception Organic Spa	Wellness / Spa	Asian-owned	The Fan / Carytown	2605 W Cary St
The Green Kitchen	Catering	Minority/Women-owned	Church Hill	314 N 25th St
Metzger Bar and Butchery	Restaurant & Butchery	Women-owned (German)	Union Hill	801 N 23rd St

Content Opportunities Research: Richmond, VA (August/September 2026)

1. Events & Festivals (August/September timeframe)

- **Richmond Jazz and Music Festival (RJMF):** Typically held in early August (e.g., August 8-9, 2026). A major event featuring prominent artists like Erykah Badu.
- **AfroFest:** The 6th Annual African Heritage Festival is scheduled for Saturday, August 29, 2026, at Laurel Park Racetrack (12 PM - 6 PM). Celebrates African culture and heritage.
- **Down Home Family Reunion:** A Celebration of African American Folklife, typically happening in mid-August (e.g., August 15, 2026, 4 PM - 11 PM).
- **2nd Street Festival:** An annual two-day celebration featuring live musical entertainment, food, and a Kidz Zone, celebrating the rich culture of the historic Jackson Ward neighborhood.
- **Iron Blossom Music Festival:** Scheduled for September 19-20, 2026. Features two days of live music and food.
- **Virginia Black Expo:** An annual event highlighting Black-owned businesses and culture.
- **RVA First Fridays:** A monthly art walk that takes place on the first Friday of each month in downtown Richmond's Arts District.

2. Farmers Markets & Pop-Up Markets

- **RVA BIG Market:** Saturdays, 8 AM - 12 PM (Summer Season: May-October) at Bryan Park (4308 Hermitage Road). A large, diverse market.
- **Richmond Night Market:** Every 2nd Saturday from 5 PM - 9 PM (April-December) at the 17th Street Market (100 N 17th St). An open-air market featuring local artisans and vendors.
- **PopUp Market at The Diamond:** Every Saturday, 10 AM - 4 PM (3001 N Arthur Ashe Blvd). A weekly vendor market.
- **South of the James Market:** A popular open-air market.
- **First Friday Pop Up Market:** Held in Richmond's Arts District during the First Friday art walks.

3. Community Organizations Worth Connecting With

- **Virginia Black Chamber of Commerce:** Advances the economic and social equities of Black business owners in Virginia. (Website: vablackchamberofcommerce.org, IG: @vablackchamber)
- **Central Virginia African American Chamber of Commerce (CVAACC):** A non-profit organization serving the African American community of the Richmond Metropolitan area, focused on business development and growth. (Website: cvaacc.org)
- **Urban League of Greater Richmond:** An affiliate of the National Urban League, supporting economic development efforts. (Website: ulgr.org, IG: @urbanleaguerichmond)
- **NAACP Virginia State Conference:** Headquartered in Richmond (PO Box 27212). (Website: naacpva.org, Phone: 804-321-5678)
- **Pine Camp Cultural Arts and Community Center:** Located in the north side of Richmond, offering various amenities and cultural programs.
- **The ARTS Community Center:** Provides a platform to explore the arts and experience growth.

4. Best Times/Days to Visit Key Areas

- **First Fridays:** The first Friday of every month (6 PM - 9 PM) is the best time to visit the Arts District in Downtown Richmond for the RVA First Fridays art walk.
- **Weekends:** Saturdays are highly active with multiple markets operating simultaneously (RVA BIG Market in the morning, PopUp Market at The Diamond during the day, and Richmond Night Market on the 2nd Saturday evening).
- **Weekly Recurring Events:**
 - **Open Mic Nights:**
 - Community Open Mic @ Black Iris (every 3rd Thursday at 7:00 PM).
 - Banditos (last Tuesday of every month).
 - Town Hall (open jam on Wednesdays).
- **Cultural Districts:** The Arts District (Broad Street) and historic neighborhoods like Jackson Ward are most vibrant during festivals (like the 2nd Street Festival) and First Fridays.
- **Museums:** The Virginia Museum of Fine Arts (VMFA) is open every day and stays open late (until 9 PM) Wednesday through Friday, making weekday evenings a good time for cultural visits.

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Raleigh/Durham, NC

Cultural Sites & Heritage Landmarks: Raleigh/Durham, NC

Historical Context

Raleigh and Durham, North Carolina, hold profound significance for the Black diaspora, serving as pivotal centers for African American education, economic prosperity, and civil rights activism. Following the Civil War, Raleigh became a beacon for Black education with the founding of Shaw University in 1865, the first Historically Black College and University (HBCU) in the South, and Saint Augustine's University in 1867. These institutions fostered a thriving Black middle class, particularly in the East Raleigh-South Park neighborhood, which remains the city's largest historically Black district. In Durham, the late 19th and early 20th centuries saw the rise of "Black Wall Street" along Parrish Street, anchored by institutions like North Carolina Mutual Life Insurance Company and Mechanics and Farmers Bank. This four-block area became a national symbol of Black economic empowerment and entrepreneurship, complementing the vibrant cultural hub of the nearby Hayti community.

The current cultural landscape of the Raleigh-Durham area is a dynamic blend of historical preservation and contemporary celebration. The heartbeat of this culture can be felt in neighborhoods like Hayti in Durham and South Park in Raleigh, where historic churches, community centers, and public art continue to tell the stories of resilience and progress. Both cities were crucial battlegrounds during the Civil Rights Movement, inspiring student-led sit-ins and nonviolent protests that rippled throughout the Jim Crow South. Today, the legacy of these movements is preserved in numerous museums, monuments, and cultural centers, making the region a rich tapestry of African American heritage and a vital destination for understanding the broader narrative of the Black experience in America.

Cultural Sites & Heritage Landmarks

1. Pope House Museum

- **Address:** 511 S. Wilmington St., Raleigh, NC 27601
- **Description:** Built in 1901, this is the only African-American house museum in North Carolina, offering a glimpse into the life of Dr. Manassa Thomas Pope, a prominent Black physician, entrepreneur, and politician during the Jim Crow era.

- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the preserved 19th-century artifacts and historical narrative on Black middle-class life and political resilience in the early 1900s.

2. Hayti Heritage Center

- **Address:** 804 Old Fayetteville St., Durham, NC 27701
- **Description:** Housed in the historic St. Joseph's AME Church, this center preserves and advances the heritage of the historic Hayti community, once a thriving hub of Black culture and commerce.
- **Content Opportunity:** Interview opportunities with local historians or community leaders, and visual content of the stunning architecture and cultural events/exhibits.

3. Black Wall Street Gardens

- **Address:** 102 W. Main St. (Corner of W. Parrish St. and N. Mangum St.), Durham, NC 27701
- **Description:** A public green space and monument commemorating Durham's historic "Black Wall Street," a four-block district that was a national epicenter of African American business and financial success in the early 20th century.
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the public artwork and monuments, and a strong location for a historical narrative stand-up about Black economic empowerment.

4. Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr. Memorial Gardens

- **Address:** 1215 Martin Luther King Jr. Blvd., Raleigh, NC 27610
- **Description:** Recognized as the first public park in the United States devoted solely to Dr. King and the Civil Rights Movement, featuring a life-size bronze statue and a water monument.
- **Content Opportunity:** B-roll and visual content of the monuments, and a reflective space for discussing the region's role in the Civil Rights Movement.

5. Shaw University

- **Address:** 118 E. South St., Raleigh, NC 27601
- **Description:** Founded in 1865, Shaw is the oldest HBCU in the South and the birthplace of the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (SNCC), a major force in the Civil Rights Movement.
- **Content Opportunity:** Historical narrative on the origins of the civil rights student movement, visual content of the historic campus (like Estey Hall), and potential interviews with students or faculty.

6. North Carolina Central University (NCCU)

- **Address:** 1801 Fayetteville St., Durham, NC 27707
- **Description:** Founded in 1910 by Dr. James E. Shepard, NCCU was the first public liberal arts institution for African Americans in the nation and remains a cornerstone of Durham's Black community.
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the campus, interviews with students/alumni about the ongoing legacy of HBCUs, and exploring the university's art museum.

7. John Chavis Memorial Park

- **Address:** 505 Martin Luther King Jr. Blvd., Raleigh, NC 27601
- **Description:** Opened in 1937 during segregation as a recreational facility for African Americans, this historic park features a restored vintage carousel and remains a vital community gathering space.
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the historic carousel and park life, and a great location to capture the community gathering aspect of Raleigh's Black history.

8. East Raleigh-South Park Historic District

- **Address:** Bounded roughly by Martin Luther King Jr. Blvd., S. East St., and S. Person St., Raleigh, NC
- **Description:** Raleigh's largest historically Black neighborhood, developed primarily between 1865 and 1940, which served as an enclave for the city's Black middle class, anchored by Shaw University.
- **Content Opportunity:** Walking tour visuals of the historic homes and churches, and a narrative on the development of Black neighborhoods post-emancipation.

9. John P. "Top" Greene African American Cultural Center

- **Address:** 401 Martin Luther King Jr. Blvd., Raleigh, NC 27601
- **Description:** Located in the South Park neighborhood, this center features exhibits that interpret the history and culture of the surrounding historic African American communities.
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the historical exhibits and a potential interview spot with local curators or community members about the preservation of neighborhood history.

10. St. Joseph AME Church

- **Address:** 2521 Fayetteville St., Durham, NC 27707
 - **Description:** A cornerstone of the Durham Black community, this historic congregation has deep roots in the Hayti neighborhood and has been a center for spiritual and social leadership for over a century.
 - **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the church, capturing the spiritual and community gathering aspect, and potential interviews with church leaders on the role of the Black church in Durham's history.
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Diaspora Businesses Research: Raleigh/Durham, NC

This guide highlights 15 diverse minority-owned and diaspora-owned businesses in the Raleigh/Durham area, representing a wide range of cultural communities. These businesses are pillars of their communities and offer authentic cultural experiences, making them excellent features for the Mapping With Melanin national tour guide.

Black-Owned

1. Liberation Station Bookstore

- **Type of Business:** Children's Bookstore
- **Cultural Community:** Black-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Raleigh (recently relocated from downtown)
- **Address:** 430 Hill Street, Raleigh, NC
- **Brief Description:** North Carolina's first Black-owned children's bookstore, founded by Victoria Scott-Miller. They specialize in children's literature that centers and celebrates Black voices and experiences.
- **Why it's a good feature:** A true community pillar with a powerful story of resilience. They provide a crucial space for representation in children's literature and host community programs, making them an inspiring interview subject.

2. The Bar Ber Shop

- **Type of Business:** Barber Shop
- **Cultural Community:** Black-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Raleigh (Multiple locations)

- **Address:** 4551 New Bern Ave, Suite 180, Raleigh, NC 27610
- **Brief Description:** A Black-owned barber shop with a diverse staff that prides itself on cutting any type of hair, regardless of race, ethnicity, or gender. They offer hot towel shaves and a welcoming environment.
- **Why it's a good feature:** Barbershops are historically significant cultural hubs in the Black community. Their emphasis on diversity and inclusion while maintaining their cultural roots makes for a great community-focused story.

Hispanic/Latino-Owned

3. Boricua Soul

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant
- **Cultural Community:** Puerto Rican & African American (Afro-Latino/Mixed Diaspora)
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Durham (American Tobacco Campus)
- **Address:** 705 Willard St, Durham, NC 27701
- **Brief Description:** A unique fusion restaurant that blends Puerto Rican cuisine with Southern soul food, reflecting the heritage of its owners. Expect dishes like empanadas, pernil, and collard greens.
- **Why it's a good feature:** Perfectly represents the "mixed diaspora" experience. The blending of two distinct culinary traditions tells a beautiful story of cultural intersection and family history.

4. Taqueria El Toro / El Toro Supermarket

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant & Supermarket
- **Cultural Community:** Mexican-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Raleigh/Garner border
- **Address:** 3600 Junction Blvd, Raleigh, NC 27603
- **Brief Description:** A legendary local spot featuring an authentic taqueria attached to a full Hispanic supermarket. Known for incredibly authentic Mexican street food and a wide selection of Latin American groceries.
- **Why it's a good feature:** It's a bustling, vibrant hub for the local Latino community. The combination of a market and a taqueria provides great visual appeal and an authentic, unpretentious cultural experience.

5. Cali Colombian Restaurant

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant
- **Cultural Community:** Colombian-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Raleigh
- **Address:** 3105 Capital Blvd, Raleigh, NC 27604
- **Brief Description:** An authentic Colombian restaurant offering traditional dishes like Bandeja Paisa, empanadas, and arepas in a lively atmosphere that celebrates Colombian culture.
- **Why it's a good feature:** Highlights the specific South American diaspora in the area. The vibrant atmosphere and hearty, traditional food make it a visually and culturally rich feature.

Caribbean-Owned

6. Golden Krust Caribbean Restaurant

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant
- **Cultural Community:** Jamaican-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Raleigh
- **Address:** 6260 Plantation Center Drive, Raleigh, NC 27616
- **Brief Description:** A staple for authentic Jamaican and Caribbean food, known for their Jamaican patties, jerk chicken, oxtail, and curries.
- **Why it's a good feature:** Represents the strong Jamaican diaspora in the Triangle. It's a go-to spot for comfort food and a taste of the islands, offering a relatable and beloved culinary experience.

7. Jerk Masters

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant
- **Cultural Community:** Caribbean-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Raleigh
- **Address:** 1909 Poole Rd, Raleigh, NC 27610
- **Brief Description:** A highly-rated local favorite serving up generous portions of authentic Caribbean cuisine, with a focus on perfectly seasoned jerk dishes.
- **Why it's a good feature:** A beloved neighborhood spot that authentically represents Caribbean culinary traditions. Great for showcasing local, independent food businesses.

African-Owned (West African & Ethiopian)

8. Awaze Ethiopian & Eritrean Cuisine

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant
- **Cultural Community:** Ethiopian/Eritrean-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Raleigh
- **Address:** 904 NE Maynard Rd, Cary, NC 27513 (Greater Raleigh area)
- **Brief Description:** Offers traditional Ethiopian and Eritrean dishes served on injera bread. Known for rich, spiced stews (wots) and a communal dining experience.
- **Why it's a good feature:** The communal style of eating Ethiopian food is visually engaging and culturally significant. It highlights the East African diaspora and their rich culinary traditions.

9. Elle Et Moi Cuisine

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant
- **Cultural Community:** West African/Nigerian-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Raleigh
- **Address:** 6109 Rock Quarry Rd Suite 105, Raleigh, NC 27610
- **Brief Description:** A highly-rated restaurant specializing in authentic Nigerian and West African cuisine, offering dishes like jollof rice, fufu, and egusi soup.
- **Why it's a good feature:** West African cuisine is a foundational element of the broader Black diaspora. Featuring this restaurant connects the dots between African roots and global diaspora foodways.

10. Hady's Restaurant International Cuisine

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant
- **Cultural Community:** West African/Senegalese-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Downtown Raleigh
- **Address:** 717 E Martin St Suite 199, Raleigh, NC 27601
- **Brief Description:** Serving a mix of African and international dishes, with a strong focus on authentic West African flavors right in the heart of downtown Raleigh.
- **Why it's a good feature:** Its downtown location makes it highly accessible, and it serves as a great ambassador for West African culture in a central urban setting.

Asian-Owned

11. MOFU Shoppe

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant
- **Cultural Community:** Asian-owned (Pan-Asian)
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Downtown Raleigh
- **Address:** 321 S Blount St, Raleigh, NC 27601
- **Brief Description:** Born from a successful food truck (Pho Nomenal Dumpling), MOFU Shoppe offers a modern take on dishes from across Asia. It's a women-owned business that brings vibrant Asian flavors to downtown.
- **Why it's a good feature:** A great success story of a food truck evolving into a brick-and-mortar staple. It represents the modern, dynamic Asian-American culinary scene.

12. Brewery Bhavana

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant, Brewery, Bookstore, & Flower Shop
- **Cultural Community:** Asian-owned (Laotian heritage)
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Downtown Raleigh
- **Address:** 218 S Blount St, Raleigh, NC 27601
- **Brief Description:** A unique, multi-concept space founded by siblings Vansana and Vanvisa Nolintha. It combines a dim sum restaurant, a craft brewery, a bookstore, and a flower shop in a beautifully designed space.
- **Why it's a good feature:** Incredibly visually appealing and conceptually unique. It beautifully marries the founders' Laotian heritage with a modern, multifaceted business model.

Middle Eastern-Owned

13. Neomonde Mediterranean

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant & Bakery
- **Cultural Community:** Lebanese-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Raleigh
- **Address:** 3817 Beryl Rd, Raleigh, NC 27607

- **Brief Description:** A Raleigh institution founded by the Saleh brothers who immigrated from Lebanon. They offer authentic Lebanese cuisine, fresh-baked pita, and a wide array of Mediterranean groceries and sweets.
- **Why it's a good feature:** A classic immigrant success story. They have been a pillar of the Raleigh food scene for decades, introducing authentic Middle Eastern flavors to the community.

14. Ajja

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant
- **Cultural Community:** Middle Eastern/Mediterranean-inspired
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Raleigh
- **Address:** 209 Bickett Blvd, Raleigh, NC 27608
- **Brief Description:** A vibrant restaurant offering sharing plates inspired by the Mediterranean, the Middle East, and the Levant, focusing on fresh, bold flavors.
- **Why it's a good feature:** Represents the contemporary Middle Eastern dining experience, focusing on the shared, communal aspect of Levantine food culture.

Indigenous/Native American-Owned

15. Triangle Native American Society (TNAS) / Visible History Exhibitions

- **Type of Business:** Cultural Organization / Art Exhibitions
 - **Cultural Community:** Native American/Indigenous
 - **Neighborhood/Area:** Raleigh (Various exhibition spaces)
 - **Address:** P.O. Box 26841, Raleigh, NC 27611 (Organization base; exhibitions vary, e.g., Raleigh municipal galleries)
 - **Brief Description:** While a non-profit rather than a traditional retail business, TNAS frequently curates and sponsors exhibitions (like "Visible History") showcasing Native American art, culture, and history in the Triangle area.
 - **Why it's a good feature:** It is crucial to acknowledge and include the original inhabitants of the land. Featuring their cultural exhibitions provides vital representation for the ~13,000 Tribal Citizens in the Wake County area and highlights Indigenous artistry.
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Content Opportunities Research: Raleigh/Durham, NC (August - September 2026)

1. Events & Festivals (August/September timeframe)

- **African American Cultural Festival of Raleigh & Wake County**
 - *Date:* Labor Day Weekend (September 5-6, 2026)
 - *Location:* Downtown Raleigh
 - *Details:* An annual celebration of African American culture expressed through visual arts, music, theatre, dance, and food. A premier event for capturing the cultural fabric of the Black community in the region.
- **Hopscotch Music Festival**
 - *Date:* September 10-12, 2026
 - *Location:* Downtown Raleigh
 - *Details:* Raleigh's biggest music weekend featuring 3 full days of performances, day parties, and VIP events. Great for interviewing local and visiting artists and capturing the vibrant music scene.
- **Raleigh's International Food Festival**
 - *Date:* Late September (Historically around Sept 27-29)
 - *Location:* North Carolina State Fairgrounds (or Downtown Raleigh depending on the year)
 - *Details:* Features global flavors, cultural experiences, desserts, traditions, and diverse vendors. Excellent for capturing multicultural food scenes.
- **OutSouth Queer Film Festival**
 - *Date:* August
 - *Location:* Durham
 - *Details:* A significant cultural event in Durham celebrating LGBTQ+ cinema and arts.
- **CaribMask Carnival**
 - *Date:* August
 - *Location:* Raleigh

- *Details:* A vibrant celebration of Caribbean culture, featuring a parade, music, food, and colorful costumes.
- **Black August in the Park**
 - *Date:* August
 - *Location:* Durham
 - *Details:* A community-focused event celebrating Black culture, resistance, and joy.
- **Lazy Daze Arts and Crafts Festival**
 - *Date:* August 22, 2026 (50th Annual)
 - *Location:* Cary (near Raleigh)
 - *Details:* A major regional arts and crafts festival.

2. Farmers Markets & Pop-Up Markets

- **Black Farmers Market**
 - *Schedule:* Every Sunday (April to November)
 - *Location:* Alternates weekly between Durham and Raleigh (e.g., 2718 Rock Quarry Rd in Raleigh).
 - *Details:* A vibrant market and "grocery store with a vibe" that supports Black farmers and entrepreneurs. Highly recommended for interviewing Black business owners and capturing community energy.
- **Durham Foodie Fare**
 - *Schedule:* Monthly (August 21st, September 18th, 5:30 PM - 9:30 PM)
 - *Location:* Durham
 - *Details:* Monthly foodie and art markets featuring 20+ food trucks, 20+ local vendors, drinks, and more.
- **The Raleigh Market (Flea Market)**
 - *Schedule:* Every Saturday and Sunday, 9:00 AM - 5:00 PM
 - *Location:* Historic NC State Fairgrounds (4285 Trinity Road, Raleigh)
 - *Details:* N.C.'s largest flea market featuring antiques, vintage items, handcrafted goods, and artisan food.
- **Pop-Up Raleigh**
 - *Schedule:* Monthly (e.g., August 15th, 12:00 PM - 5:00 PM)
 - *Location:* Trophy on Maywood (Raleigh)

- *Details:* Monthly art and vintage markets.
- **Moore Square Market**
 - *Schedule:* Weekly
 - *Location:* Downtown Raleigh (Moore Square)
 - *Details:* Highlights local vendors, farm-fresh food, and artisanal goods in the heart of the city.

3. Community Organizations Worth Connecting With

- **Black Chamber Raleigh**
 - *Focus:* Minority business advocacy organization supporting Black-owned businesses, entrepreneurs, and professionals in Raleigh.
 - *Contact:* (919) 292-9791 | Website: blackchamberraleigh.com | Social: @blackchamberraleigh
- **The Greater Durham Black Chamber of Commerce (GDBCC)**
 - *Focus:* Empowers, supports, and develops Black entrepreneurs and the business community in Durham.
 - *Contact:* Social: @thegdbcc
- **John P. "Top" Greene African American Cultural Center**
 - *Focus:* Features historical exhibits interpreting the history and culture of the South Park and East Raleigh neighborhoods.
 - *Location:* Raleigh, NC
- **Hayti Heritage Center**
 - *Focus:* A cultural enrichment and arts education facility that preserves and advances the heritage and culture of the historic Hayti community in Durham.
 - *Location:* 804 Old Fayetteville St., Durham, NC 27701
- **NAACP Durham Branch**
 - *Focus:* Local chapter of the national civil rights organization.
 - *Contact:* Office: 919-294-6613 | Email: 5387secretary@naacpunti.org | Location: 2726 Croasdaile Dr. #205, Durham, NC 27705
- **National Urban League (Local Affiliates)**
 - *Focus:* Civil rights and urban advocacy organization.
 - *Contact:* Durham contact info: (919) 683-1801

- **Diamante Arts and Cultural Center**
 - *Focus:* The oldest Latino/Hispanic Arts and Culture organization in the area.
 - *Contact:* (919) 474-8370 | Location: Durham, NC

4. Best Times/Days to Visit Key Areas

- **Weekends (Friday - Sunday):**
 - This is the optimal time to capture the most vibrant cultural fabric. Major festivals (like the African American Cultural Festival and Hopscotch) happen over the weekend.
 - The **Black Farmers Market** on Sundays is a must-visit for community engagement and business owner interviews.
 - **The Raleigh Market** is bustling on Saturdays and Sundays.
- **Weekdays (Monday - Thursday):**
 - Better for scheduling one-on-one interviews with business owners and community leaders (e.g., Chamber of Commerce representatives) when they are less busy with weekend events.
 - **Tuesdays:** Open Mic Night at Slim's Dive Bar in Downtown Raleigh.
 - **First Thursdays:** Open Mic Night at Unity of the Triangle (Raleigh).
 - **Second Sundays:** Tongue & Groove monthly open mic in downtown Raleigh (poets, musicians, storytellers).
- **Cultural Districts:**
 - **Downtown Raleigh:** Most active during weekend evenings and during major festivals.
 - **Historic Hayti District (Durham):** Check the Hayti Heritage Center's schedule for specific events, but generally active during community gatherings and weekend programs.
 - **Southeast Raleigh:** The site of the upcoming African American Cultural Center and a hub for Black cultural life.

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Charlotte, NC

Cultural Sites Research: Charlotte, NC

Historical Context

Charlotte, North Carolina, holds a profound significance for the Black diaspora, shaped by a history of resilience, community building, and civil rights activism. Following emancipation, formerly enslaved people established thriving neighborhoods like Brooklyn in the Second Ward, which became known as the "Black Wall Street of Charlotte." This area, along with others like Biddleville and Optimist Park, fostered Black-owned businesses, schools, and churches. However, the urban renewal policies of the 1960s and 70s decimated many of these communities, displacing residents and erasing physical history. Despite these challenges, the spirit of these neighborhoods endured, and today, there is a strong movement to preserve and celebrate this heritage. The city was also a crucial battleground during the Civil Rights Movement, with students from Johnson C. Smith University leading peaceful sit-ins in 1960 that successfully desegregated local lunch counters, and activists like Reginald Hawkins pushing for broader integration.

Today, the cultural heartbeat of Black Charlotte is most palpable in the Historic West End, which encompasses neighborhoods like Biddleville and Washington Heights. This area remains a vibrant hub for education, art, and activism, anchored by Johnson C. Smith University. The current cultural landscape is a dynamic blend of historical preservation and contemporary expression, visible in the numerous murals adorning the city, the thriving arts scene at institutions like the Gantt Center, and the ongoing efforts of organizations like Historic West End Partners to stimulate economic development while honoring the past. Charlotte's Black history is not just a relic of the past; it is a living, breathing force that continues to shape the city's identity and future.

Cultural Sites & Heritage Landmarks

1. Harvey B. Gantt Center for African-American Arts + Culture

- **Address:** 551 South Tryon Street, Charlotte, NC 28202
- **Description:** Named after Charlotte's first Black mayor, this center is the premier destination in the city for African-American art, history, and culture, hosting diverse exhibits and community events.
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of contemporary and historical art exhibits, interviews with local artists or curators, and coverage of community events like Jazz @ the Gantt.

2. Johnson C. Smith University (JCSU)

- **Address:** 100 Beatties Ford Road, Charlotte, NC 28216

- **Description:** Founded in 1867, JCSU is a historically Black university (HBCU) that has been a beacon of education and a center for civil rights activism, including the 1960 student-led sit-ins.
- **Content Opportunity:** Historical narrative on the role of HBCUs in the Civil Rights Movement, visual content of the historic campus (like Biddle Hall), and interviews with current students or faculty about the university's ongoing legacy.

3. Charlotte Museum of History (Alexander Rock House)

- **Address:** 3500 Shamrock Drive, Charlotte, NC 28215
- **Description:** The museum grounds feature the 1774 Alexander Rock House, the oldest surviving house in Mecklenburg County, which was built by 17 enslaved people, offering a stark look at the region's early history.
- **Content Opportunity:** Historical narrative on the lives of enslaved people in early Charlotte, visual content of the historic structure, and exploration of the museum's exhibits on Charlotte's Black neighborhoods.

4. First United Presbyterian Church

- **Address:** 201 E 7th St, Charlotte, NC 28202
- **Description:** Founded in 1869 by formerly enslaved people, this historic Gothic Revival church served as a sanctuary and a resting place for activists during the Civil Rights Movement.
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the historic architecture, historical narrative on the role of the Black church in community building and civil rights, and potential interviews with long-standing congregation members.

5. The Brooklyn Collective (Grace A.M.E. Zion Church)

- **Address:** 219 S Brevard St, Charlotte, NC 28202
- **Description:** Located in what remains of the historic Brooklyn neighborhood, this collective includes the 1902 Grace A.M.E. Zion Church and works to promote inclusivity and preserve the history of Charlotte's "Black Wall Street."
- **Content Opportunity:** Historical narrative on the rise and fall of the Brooklyn neighborhood due to urban renewal, visual content of the historic church, and interviews with organizers working on economic mobility.

6. "Historic Brooklyn" Mural by Abel Jackson

- **Address:** 219 S. Brevard St., Charlotte, NC 28202

- **Description:** This mural pays homage to the prominent African American educators, entrepreneurs, and civic leaders who founded and built the thriving Brooklyn neighborhood.
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the mural, historical narrative on the figures depicted (like Thaddeus Tate and Dr. J.T. Williams), and a discussion on the importance of public art in preserving erased histories.

7. Charles Jones Mural

- **Address:** Corner of Bruns Avenue and Fifth Street, Charlotte, NC
- **Description:** A layered tapestry honoring J. Charles Jones, a key civil rights activist and attorney who led the JCSU student sit-ins in the 1960s.
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the mural, historical narrative on local civil rights leadership, and a reflection on the ongoing fight for social justice.

8. Romare Bearden Park

- **Address:** 300 S Church St, Charlotte, NC 28202
- **Description:** A beautiful urban park dedicated to the Charlotte-born, internationally renowned artist Romare Bearden, whose work focused on the Black community and experience.
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the park's design and water features, historical narrative on Bearden's life and artistic contributions, and capturing the park as a modern community gathering spot.

9. "NC 8" Mural

- **Address:** 1600 W. Trade St., Charlotte, NC 28216
- **Description:** Created by T'Afo Feimster and Abel Jackson, this mural honors eight influential Black musicians from North Carolina, including Nina Simone, John Coltrane, and George Clinton.
- **Content Opportunity:** Visual content of the mural, historical narrative on North Carolina's immense contribution to Black music and culture, and a vibrant backdrop for discussing the arts.

10. Historic West End (Biddleville & Washington Heights)

- **Address:** Beatties Ford Road Corridor (around JCSU), Charlotte, NC
- **Description:** The only surviving intact concentration of historic Black neighborhoods in Charlotte, serving as the epicenter for civil rights actions and a current hub for Black

culture and business.

- **Content Opportunity:** A walking tour capturing the neighborhood's vibe, interviews with local business owners or residents about gentrification and preservation, and visual content of the various murals and historic markers along the corridor.
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Diverse Diaspora-Owned Businesses in Charlotte, NC

Charlotte, North Carolina, is home to a vibrant and diverse array of minority-owned and diaspora-owned businesses. The following list highlights 15 authentic businesses representing various cultural communities, making them excellent features for the Mapping With Melanin national tour guide app.

1. Mert's Heart and Soul

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant (Soul Food)
- **Cultural Community:** Black-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Uptown
- **Address:** 214 N College St, Charlotte, NC 28202
- **Brief Description:** A staple in Uptown Charlotte, Mert's offers award-winning Southern, Gullah, and Lowcountry cuisine, including their famous salmon cakes and soul rolls.
- **Why it would be a good feature:** As a long-standing community pillar in the heart of the city, Mert's has a rich history and is widely recognized, making it a perfect subject for interviews and filming.

2. Urban Reader Bookstore

- **Type of Business:** Bookstore
- **Cultural Community:** Black-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** University City Area / Concord
- **Address:** 440 E McCullough Dr, Suite A-130, Charlotte, NC 28262
- **Brief Description:** Charlotte's only Black-owned indie bookstore, specializing in African American literature, banned books, and New York bestsellers. They also operate a bookmobile.

- **Why it would be a good feature:** A literary hub dedicated to amplifying Black voices and authors. The unique aspect of their bookmobile provides a great visual and storytelling element.

3. Enat Ethiopian Restaurant

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant (Ethiopian)
- **Cultural Community:** Ethiopian-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** East Charlotte / Plaza Midwood Area
- **Address:** 4150 Maney Dr, Charlotte, NC 28205
- **Brief Description:** Known for its authentic and flavorful Ethiopian dishes served on traditional injera bread, offering a communal dining experience.
- **Why it would be a good feature:** The communal style of eating and the vibrant colors of the food offer fantastic visual appeal, while the authentic cultural representation highlights the East African diaspora.

4. Sabor Latin Street Grill

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant (Latin American)
- **Cultural Community:** Hispanic/Latino-owned (Venezuelan roots)
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Multiple locations (Original in Elizabeth)
- **Address:** 415 Hawthorne Ln, Charlotte, NC 28204 (Elizabeth location)
- **Brief Description:** A locally owned concept focusing on authentic menu offerings from countries such as El Salvador, Dominican Republic, Venezuela, Mexico, and Colombia.
- **Why it would be a good feature:** It showcases the diversity within the Latin American diaspora itself, offering a pan-Latin experience that is highly popular and accessible in Charlotte.

5. Calle Sol Café & Cevicheria

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant (Latin/Peruvian/Cuban)
- **Cultural Community:** Hispanic/Latino-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Plaza Midwood
- **Address:** 1205 Thomas Ave, Charlotte, NC 28205
- **Brief Description:** A vibrant spot serving authentic Latin, Peruvian, and Cuban food, known for its bold flavors, ceviche, and lively atmosphere.

- **Why it would be a good feature:** The specific focus on Peruvian and Cuban cuisine adds distinct regional Latin flavors, and the vibrant, colorful setting is ideal for filming.

6. Mi Tierra Colombian Restaurant

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant (Colombian)
- **Cultural Community:** Colombian-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** South Charlotte
- **Address:** 10405 Park Rd, Charlotte, NC 28210
- **Brief Description:** An authentic Colombian restaurant offering traditional dishes like Bandeja Paisa, empanadas, and arepas in a welcoming environment.
- **Why it would be a good feature:** It provides a deep dive into South American diaspora culture, specifically Colombian, which is a growing and vibrant community in Charlotte.

7. Caribbean Hut

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant (Caribbean)
- **Cultural Community:** Caribbean-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** University City
- **Address:** 9609 N Tryon St, Charlotte, NC 28262
- **Brief Description:** Serving up authentic Caribbean flavors, including jerk chicken, oxtail, and curry goat, bringing the taste of the islands to Charlotte.
- **Why it would be a good feature:** A beloved spot for authentic island cuisine, representing the strong Caribbean diaspora in the city with visually appealing, hearty dishes.

8. Lagz Restaurant

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant (Nigerian/West African)
- **Cultural Community:** West African-owned (Nigerian)
- **Neighborhood/Area:** East Charlotte
- **Address:** 3130 N Tryon St, Charlotte, NC 28206
- **Brief Description:** One of the best Nigerian restaurants in Charlotte, serving authentic West African flavors, including jollof rice, fufu, and egusi soup, often featuring an unlimited buffet.

- **Why it would be a good feature:** Highlights the rich culinary traditions of West Africa. The buffet and traditional dishes offer a great opportunity to showcase diverse food cultures.

9. The Dumpling Lady

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant / Food Truck (Asian)
- **Cultural Community:** Asian-owned (Chinese)
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Optimist Hall / South End
- **Address:** 1115 N Brevard St, Charlotte, NC 28206 (Optimist Hall)
- **Brief Description:** Starting as a popular food truck and now a staple in Optimist Hall, serving authentic, spicy Sichuan-style dumplings and noodles.
- **Why it would be a good feature:** A massive local success story that brings authentic, regional Chinese street food to the forefront of Charlotte's culinary scene.

10. Let's Meat Kbbq

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant (Korean BBQ)
- **Cultural Community:** Asian-owned (Korean)
- **Neighborhood/Area:** South End
- **Address:** 1400 S Church St, Charlotte, NC 28203
- **Brief Description:** Charlotte's premier all-you-can-eat authentic Korean BBQ experience, where diners cook their own meats at the table.
- **Why it would be a good feature:** The interactive nature of Korean BBQ makes for highly engaging video content, and it represents a significant aspect of Asian culinary culture.

11. La Shish Kabob

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant (Middle Eastern)
- **Cultural Community:** Middle Eastern-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** East Charlotte
- **Address:** 3117 N Sharon Amity Rd, Charlotte, NC 28205
- **Brief Description:** A locally owned Middle Eastern restaurant serving a wide variety of fresh, authentic foods including shawarma, falafel, and kabobs.

- **Why it would be a good feature:** Represents the Middle Eastern diaspora with authentic, fresh cuisine in a neighborhood known for its diverse immigrant communities.

12. Zaytuna

- **Type of Business:** Market / Grocery Store
- **Cultural Community:** Palestinian-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** East Charlotte
- **Address:** 4200 South Blvd, Charlotte, NC 28209
- **Brief Description:** A neighborhood market offering a wide selection of Middle Eastern and Mediterranean groceries, spices, and halal meats.
- **Why it would be a good feature:** Markets are cultural hubs. Showcasing a Palestinian-owned grocery store highlights the ingredients and daily life of the Middle Eastern diaspora.

13. Curio, Craft & Conjure

- **Type of Business:** Retail / Wellness
- **Cultural Community:** Black-owned
- **Neighborhood/Area:** NoDa (North Davidson)
- **Address:** 3204 N Davidson St, Suite C, Charlotte, NC 28205
- **Brief Description:** A unique shop supplying personalized magickal supplies, herbs, crystals, and offering spiritual services.
- **Why it would be a good feature:** Offers a completely different angle from food, focusing on spiritual wellness and alternative retail within the Black community.

14. Viva Chicken

- **Type of Business:** Restaurant (Peruvian)
- **Cultural Community:** Hispanic/Latino-owned (Peruvian roots)
- **Neighborhood/Area:** Multiple locations (Elizabeth, Ballantyne, etc.)
- **Address:** 1617 Elizabeth Ave, Charlotte, NC 28204 (Elizabeth location)
- **Brief Description:** A fast-casual charcoal-fire rotisserie joint specializing in authentic Peruvian Pollo a la Brasa.

- **Why it would be a good feature:** A highly successful local chain that introduced many Charlotteans to Peruvian flavors, showcasing the successful scaling of a diaspora-owned business.

15. Nile Grocery and Ethiopian Restaurant

- **Type of Business:** Market and Restaurant
 - **Cultural Community:** Ethiopian-owned
 - **Neighborhood/Area:** East Charlotte
 - **Address:** 3113 N Sharon Amity Rd, Charlotte, NC 28205
 - **Brief Description:** A dual-purpose business offering both a grocery store stocked with East African goods and a restaurant serving traditional Ethiopian meals.
 - **Why it would be a good feature:** The combination of a market and a restaurant provides a comprehensive look at how the Ethiopian diaspora maintains its culture and serves its community in Charlotte.
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Content Opportunities: Charlotte, NC (August/September 2026)

1. Events & Festivals (August/September timeframe)

- **Charlotte International Arts Festival (CIAF):** Typically runs mid-September to early October (e.g., Sept 13-29). Features immersive art installations, live performances, and cultural experiences spanning from Uptown Charlotte to Ballantyne.
- **Matthews Alive Labor Day Festival:** Late August to early September (Labor Day weekend). Features live music, rides, games, vendors, art, and cultural booths.
- **UNC Charlotte International Festival:** Usually takes place in September. A celebration of diverse cultures with food, performances, and art.
- **Carolina Bloom Music Festival:** Typically late August (e.g., Aug 22-23). An indie and alternative rock music festival in the Iron District.
- **Breakaway Carolina:** Late September (e.g., Sept 25-26). A major music festival in Charlotte.
- **FoodieLand Food Festival:** Mid-September (e.g., Sept 18-20). A nationwide food festival with 250+ vendors featuring global flavors, artisan shops, games, and live music.

- **Foodees Fest:** Mid-September (e.g., Sept 11-13). Features 40+ food vendors, crafters, and artisans.
- **PANDA FEST:** One of the biggest outdoor Asian food festivals featuring 80+ Asian food vendors and 200+ Asian street food items. (Dates vary, often late summer/fall).
- **Charlotte Pride Festival & Parade:** Typically mid-August (e.g., Aug 15-16).

2. Farmers Markets & Pop-Up Markets

- **Charlotte Regional Farmers Market:** Located on Yorkmont Road. A large, state-run market with diverse vendors. Open Tuesday-Sunday (busiest on weekends).
- **Matthews Community Farmer's Market:** One of the largest, most diverse producers-only farmers markets in the greater Charlotte area. Open Saturdays.
- **The Neighborhood Farmers Market:** Various locations including University City, Wesley Heights, and LoSo. Open Saturdays (10 AM - 1 PM).
- **Nebel's Alley Night Market:** Located in South End. Features 32 local vendors, live music, food, and entertainment. (Dates vary, often monthly).
- **Asian Night Market:** Located at Urban District Market. (e.g., Friday evenings, 5 PM - 11 PM).
- **Pink Pop Collective Market:** Located at Urban District Market. A pop-up event featuring local vendors.
- **Concord Flea Market & Miller's Flea Market:** Popular local flea markets for artisan and second-hand goods.

3. Community Organizations Worth Connecting With

- **Charlotte Mecklenburg Black Chamber of Commerce (CMBCC):** A non-profit organization serving black-owned businesses in the Charlotte Mecklenburg region. (Contact: office@naricharlotte.com, 704-212-2032).
- **Greater NC Black Chamber of Commerce:** Serves as a voice for Black businesses and hosts events bringing together community leaders and entrepreneurs.
- **Latin Chamber of Commerce of the Carolinas:** A key resource for connecting with the Hispanic business community in Charlotte.
- **The Harvey B. Gantt Center for African-American Arts + Culture:** Celebrates the contributions of Africans and African-Americans to American culture. A prime location for cultural fabric and community connection.

- **Culture Blocks:** Connects communities with responsive arts, science, and history experiences close to where residents live.
- **Little Rock Cultural Center:** Hosts cultural events, community festivals, plays, and jazz performances.
- **NAACP Charlotte-Mecklenburg Branch (#5376):** Stands at the forefront of the fight for racial and social justice in the community. (Contact: naACP@charlottenAACP.com, 704-452-5269).
- **Urban League of Central Carolinas (ULCC):** Advocates for and equips African Americans and underserved communities with tools to achieve social and economic equality.

4. Best Times/Days to Visit Key Areas

- **Weekends (Saturday/Sunday):** The best time to visit cultural districts like South End, NoDa (North Davidson), and Uptown. Farmers markets (like the Regional Market and Matthews Market) are most active on Saturday mornings. Festivals and large events almost exclusively happen on weekends.
- **Weekdays:** Good for visiting museums (like the Gantt Center) and connecting with business owners and chamber of commerce leaders during regular business hours.
- **Recurring Events:**
 - **Open Mic Nights:** The Evening Muse hosts Tosco Music's Open Mic Night (e.g., Tuesdays at 6:30 PM). Jambox typically hosts an Open Mic on the third Wednesday of the month (7 PM).
 - **Night Markets:** Events like Nebel's Alley Night Market and the Asian Night Market often happen on Friday or Saturday evenings.
- **Weather Note:** September is generally considered one of the best times to visit Charlotte as the intense summer heat begins to break, making outdoor filming and festivals much more pleasant.

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